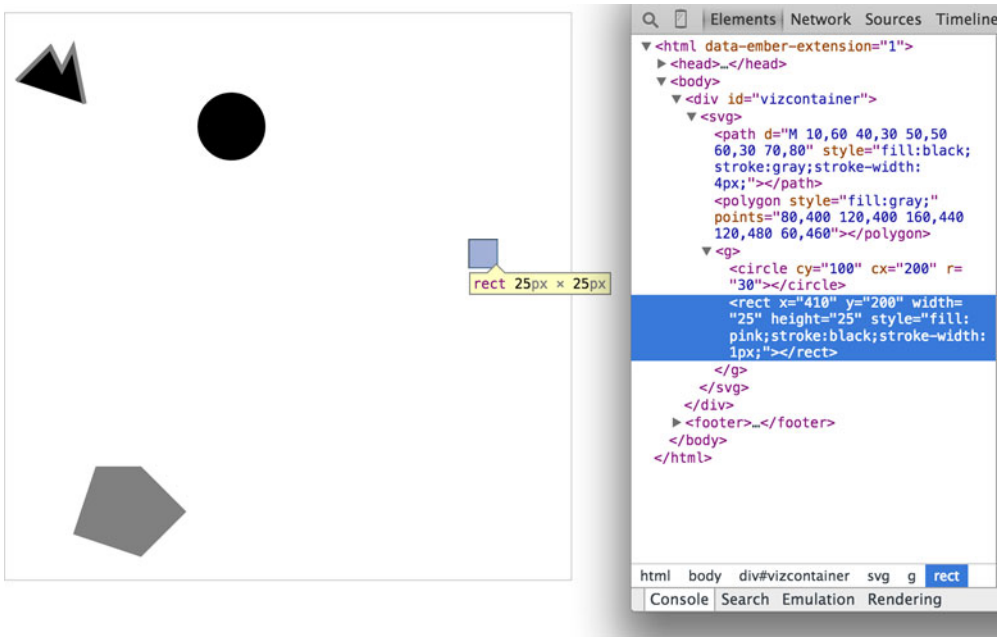


Figure 1.18 Modifying the height and width attributes of a `<rect>` element changes the appearance of that element. Inspecting the element also shows how the stroke adds to the computed size of the element.[1]

Infoviz term: geometric primitive

Accomplished artists can draw anything with vector graphics, but you're probably not looking at D3 because you're an artist. Instead, you're dealing with graphics and have more pragmatic goals in mind. From that perspective, it's important to understand the concept of geometric primitives (also known as graphical primitives). Geometric primitives are simple shapes such as points, lines, circles, and rectangles. These shapes, which can be combined to make more complex graphics, are particularly useful for visually displaying information.

Primitives are also useful for understanding complex information visualizations that you see out in the real world. Dendrograms like the one shown in figure 1.20 are far less intimidating when you realize they're just circles and lines. Interactive timelines are easier to understand and create when you think of them as collections of rectangles and points. Even geographic data, which primarily comes in the form of polygons, points, and lines, is less confusing when you break it down into its most basic graphical structures.

[1] Figures that have a picture icon at the end of the caption, like figure 1.18, have an online example that you can work with interactively or download to run locally. Click on the icon in the eBook version of the book, or go to manning.com/meeks to find all interactive examples online.